



◀ Native medicine

Samoan women here prepare kawakawa, one of the key healing herbs in *rongoā*—traditional Māori medicine. Women all over the world have practiced herbal medicine since antiquity.

THROUGH THE AGES

Medicine

Women have always worked as healers, herbalists, nurses, and midwives, but they were largely excluded from the male-dominated medical profession. However, since the mid-19th century, increasing numbers of women have trained to become physicians and surgeons.

THE FIRST RECORDED FEMALE PHYSICIAN

in history was Merit-Ptah, who held a senior position at the pharaoh's court in Egypt in c. 2700 BCE, but before the 19th century such a role was very rare. Even when women were

allowed to practice medicine, they focused mostly on gynecological and

obstetrical health, and worked as midwives. Women were also

herbalists who used plants to treat illnesses. Denied

access to trade guilds and universities, most females were trained informally. An exception was in

convents, where women like 12th-century German abbess Hildegard of Bingen wrote texts in

order to train nuns to perform medicine.

HILDEGARD OF BINGEN 12TH-CENTURY PORTRAIT



In the 19th century women campaigned for the right to formally train as doctors. Pioneering figures such as Elizabeth Garrett Anderson found ways around the sexist attitudes of the mainstream medical profession. Born in London, Garrett Anderson was inspired to become a doctor after meeting Elizabeth Blackwell, the first female doctor to

“It is ... the **instinct of ... women** to appear as **physicians** ...”

ANN PRESTON, FIRST FEMALE DEAN OF A MEDICAL COLLEGE